

Supper As Memorial

doc-supper-as-memorial

Sacraments · Lord's Supper · doctrine · divided_lineages

DISPUTED

breadth canon-wide

directness direct

variants stable

Statement under examination

The Lord's Supper is primarily a memorial of Christ's once-for-all atoning death; 'do this in remembrance of me.'

In plain language

The verses that institute the Lord's Supper use a specific Greek phrase, 'for my remembrance' (eis ten emen anamnesin), meaning for my remembrance or as my memorial. It appears in Luke 22:19 and twice in 1 Corinthians 11, attached to the command 'do this', where the verb is 'do or make' (poieo), an ongoing instruction. The word 'remembrance' (anamnesis) occurs only four times in the whole New Testament, and the fourth use settles its meaning: in Hebrews 10:3 it names the yearly reminder of sins made by the old sacrifices, so the word means a calling to mind, not a re-doing of a sacrifice. Paul adds in 1 Corinthians 11:26 that whenever believers eat the bread and drink the cup they 'proclaim' (katangello) the Lord's death until he comes, the language of public announcement. Hebrews 10 reinforces this: the body of Jesus was offered 'once for all' (ephapax) as one sacrifice, and by that one offering 'he has perfected' (tetelaiken, in the completed perfect tense, a completed action whose result still stands) those being made holy. The death is finished and not repeated. The memorial idea also has deep roots: the Passover is called 'a memorial' (zikkaron) in Exodus 12:14, and the sanctuary bread 'a memorial portion' (azkarah) in Leviticus 24:7, which the older Greek translation (the Septuagint) renders with this same word 'remembrance' (anamnesis). So calling the Supper a memorial of a once-for-all death is on very firm lexical ground. The contested word in the proposition is 'primarily'. The same apostle who gives the remembrance command in chapter 11 calls the same cup and bread 'a participation or communion' (koinonia) in the blood and body of Christ in 1 Corinthians 10:16, and says we all 'partake' (metechomen) of the one loaf in 10:17. The short linking verb 'is' (estin) in 'this is my body' sits without any qualifier. The words clearly put both remembrance and participation in view, but they never rank one above the other, so the text alone cannot decide whether memorial is the single primary function or one true function among others. For that reason the lexical reading is recorded as disputed rather than simply affirmed.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
H0234	אֶזְכָּרָה	azkarah	memorial	6
H2146	זִכְרוֹן	zikkaron	memorial	23
H2282	חַג	chag	feast	
G0037	ἁγιάζω	hagiazō	to sanctify	29
G0266	ἁμαρτία	hamartia	sin	
G0364	ἀνάμνησις	anamnesis	remembrance	4
G0740	ἄρτος	artos	bread	

G1242	διαθήκη	diatheke	covenant	33
G1336	διηνεκής	dienekes	perpetual	4
G1510	εἰμί	eimi	to be	2,457
G2178	ἐφάπαξ	ephapax	once/at once	5
G2378	θυσία	thysia	sacrifice	29
G2605	καταγγέλλω	katangelo	to proclaim	17
G2806	κλάω	klaō	to break	
G2842	κοινωνία	koinonia	participation	16
G3348	μετέχω	metecho	to share	8
G3740	ὅσάκις	hosakis	whenever	3
G3860	παραδίδωμι	paradidōmi	to deliver	
G4160	ποιέω	poieo	to do/make	568
G4221	ποτήριον	potērion	cup	
G4374	προσφέρω	prospherō	to bring to	
G4376	προσφορά	prosphora	offering	9
G4983	σῶμα	soma	body	144
G5048	τελειόω	teleioo	to perfect	23
G5228	ὑπέρ	huper	above/for	

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

The noun 'remembrance' (anamnesis, G0364) in the purpose clause 'for my remembrance' (eis ten emen anamnesin) appears in Luke 22:19 and twice in 1 Corinthians 11:24-25, attached to the command 'do' (poieite, G4160), and its sense is fixed by its only other canonical use, Hebrews 10:3, where the same word names the yearly 'reminder of sins' (anamnesis hamartion) of the repeated Old Testament sacrifices. That control plus the Greek Old Testament (the Septuagint, LXX) memorial vocabulary it renders ('memorial' zikkaron, H2146, Exodus 12:14 Passover; 'memorial portion' azkarah, H0234, Leviticus 24:7) and 1 Corinthians 11:26 'you proclaim' (katangellete, G2605, until he comes) make remembrance and proclamation of a once-for-all finished death (Hebrews 10:10-14 'once for all' ephapax, 'one sacrifice' mian thysian, 'he has perfected' tetelaiken in the perfect tense, a completed action whose result still stands) a secure lexical function of the rite. The dispute is one of scope, not of whether memorial is present. The same apostle calls the same elements a 'participation or communion' (koinonia, G2842) of the body and blood in 1 Corinthians 10:16 and says 'we partake' (metechomen, G3348) of the one loaf in 10:17, and the bare linking verb 'is' (estin) in 'this is my body' (touto estin to soma mou) is unqualified. The vocabulary affirms memorial but does not rank it as the sole or primary function over participation, so the proposition's word 'primarily' is lexically underdetermined and the verdict is disputed.

Scripture

Luke.22.19 · for · genre: gospel · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G0364 ανάμνησις, G4160 ποιέω, G4983 σῶμα

Force. The command 'do this for my remembrance' (poieite touto eis ten emen anamnesin) attaches the rite to a remembrance of Christ. The verb is 'do or make' (poieo, G4160), in the present imperative (an ongoing, commanded action), and the participle 'given on your behalf' (didomenon) points to the atoning death the act recalls. The linking verb 'is' in 'this is my body' (touto estin to soma mou) is the unmarked 'is' (estin, G1510) with no qualifier, so the verb itself does not specify whether the bread commemorates the body or relates to it in some fuller way. That open linking verb is where the 'primarily' claim becomes contested.

1Cor.11.24 · for · genre: epistle · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G0364 ανάμνησις, G4160 ποιέω, G4983 σῶμα

Force. Paul repeats 'do this for my remembrance' (touto poieite eis ten emen anamnesin), doubling the remembrance frame and tying it to 'the body on your behalf' (to soma to hyper hymon). The repetition inside the tradition Paul says 'I received' (parelabon) and 'I delivered' (paredoka) shows the remembrance function is fixed in the earliest transmitted institution wording. The same unqualified 'is' (estin) sits in 'this is my body' (touto estin to soma mou).

1Cor.11.25 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0364 ανάμνησις, G4221 ποτήριον, G1242 διαθήκη

Force. The cup is 'the new covenant in my blood' (kaine diatheke en to emo haimati), and the same 'for my remembrance' (eis ten emen anamnesin) clause governs the drinking. The covenant-blood language situates the rite within sacrificial and covenant categories while the 'remembrance' (anamnesis) clause keeps the explicit stated purpose commemorative. Covenant-sign and remembrance functions sit side by side in the wording without one being ranked above the other.

1Cor.11.26 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3740 ὅσάκις, G2605 καταγγέλλω, G0740 ἄρτος

Force. 'For as often as you eat' (hosakis gar ean esthiete) with the verb 'you proclaim the Lord's death' (ton thanaton tou kyriou katangellete), defines the act as a recurring proclamation, bounded by 'until he comes' (achri hou elthe). The verb 'proclaim' (katangelo, G2605) occurs 17 times in the canon and dominantly means to proclaim or declare publicly, as in Acts and the Pauline letters, so the rite is described in the vocabulary of announcement, not of re-performing the death. Proclamation of a past death plus expectation of a future coming is the lexical shape of a commemorative and forward-looking sign.

1Cor.10.16 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2842 κοινωνία, G4983 σῶμα, G2806 κλάω

Force. The same apostle who gives the 'remembrance' (anamnesis) command in chapter 11 calls the cup a 'participation or communion' (koinonia, G2842) of the blood of Christ and the broken bread a 'participation or communion' (koinonia) of the body of Christ. The word 'participation or communion' (koinonia) occurs 16 times in the canon and carries the sense of fellowship, communion, or participation. This text complicates the proposition because it applies participation language to the very same elements, and the words do not rank participation against remembrance, leaving open whether memorial is the sole or primary function.

1Cor.10.17 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3348 μετέχω, G0740 ἄρτος, G4983 σῶμα

Force. Because there is one loaf, the many are one body, for we all 'partake' (metechomen, G3348) of the one loaf. The verb 'partake' (metecho) means to share in or partake of, and it joins 'participation or communion' (koinonia) in framing the eating as a real sharing in the one body. This adds to the participation reading that competes with a bare-memorial reading on the question of scope, while not displacing the remembrance language of chapter 11.

Heb.10.3 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0364 ἀνάμνησις, G0266 ἁμαρτία, G2378 θυσία

Force. This is the only other canonical use of 'remembrance' (anamnesis, G0364) and it controls the sense of the word in the institution texts. The repeated yearly sacrifices produce 'in them a reminder of sins year by year' (en autais anamnesis hamarton kat eniauton). Here 'remembrance' (anamnesis) plainly means a calling to mind, a reminder, set against the sacrifices that can never take sins away. The same writer's vocabulary thus uses 'remembrance' (anamnesis) for an act of remembrance, not for a repetition of the sacrifice itself, which constrains the sense of remembrance in Luke 22:19 and 1 Corinthians 11.

Heb.10.10 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4376 προσφορά, G4983 σῶμα, G0037 ἀγιάζω

Force. Believers are sanctified 'through the offering of the body of Jesus Christ once for all' (dia tes prosphoras tou somatos Iesou Christou ephapax). The word 'once for all' (ephapax, G2178) marks the offering as singular and unrepeatable, which constrains any reading that would make a later rite a repetition of the offering.

Heb.10.12 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2378 θυσία, G1336 διηνεκής, G4374 προσφέρω

Force. 'Having offered one sacrifice for sins forever, he sat down' (mian hyper hamarton prosenenkas thysian eis to dienekes ekathisen). The single sacrifice ('one sacrifice' mian thysian) and the seating signal a completed, non-recurring offering. The same context (Hebrews 10:1) uses 'forever or perpetual' (dienekes, G1336) of the yearly sacrifices that can never perfect, sharpening the contrast between the repeated reminder and the one finished offering.

Heb.10.14 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4376 προσφορά, G5048 τελειόω, G0037 ἀγιάζω

Force. 'For by one offering he has perfected forever those being sanctified' (mia gar prosphora tetelaiken eis to dienekes tous hagiazonous). The word 'he has perfected' (tetelaiken) is from 'perfect or complete' (teleioo, G5048) in the perfect tense (a completed action whose result still stands), which lexically closes the atoning offering as finished and not in need of repetition.

Exod.12.14 · for · genre: law

Key terms. H2146 זִכְרוֹן, H2282 חַג

Force. The Passover is appointed 'for a memorial' (le-zikkaron, H2146), to be kept as 'a feast' (chag), throughout the generations. The word 'memorial' (zikkaron) occurs 23 times in the Old Testament for memorial objects and observances, and it is the conceptual root behind the New Testament remembrance language for a covenant meal. The cross-reference graph links Exodus 12:14 to 1 Corinthians 11:24, showing the institution wording draws on this established memorial-feast pattern.

Lev.24.7 · for · genre: law

Key terms. H0234 אֶזְכָּרָה

Force. The bread set in rows before the LORD carries frankincense 'as a memorial portion' (le-azkarah, H0234). The Greek Old Testament (the Septuagint) renders 'memorial portion' (azkarah) here with 'remembrance' (anamnesis), the same Greek noun used in the institution texts, so the bread-memorial vocabulary of the sanctuary stands in the lexical background of 'for my remembrance' (eis ten emen anamnesin). This grounds the remembrance term in an established cultic memorial sense rather than a novel coinage.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Luke.22.19	1Cor.11.23	openbible	30

Luke.22.19	1Cor.10.16	openbible	25
Luke.22.19	Mark.14.22	openbible	18
Luke.22.19	Luke.22.20	openbible	17
1Cor.11.24	John.6.53	openbible	19
1Cor.11.24	1Cor.10.16	openbible	7
1Cor.11.24	Exod.12.14	openbible	7
1Cor.11.24	1Cor.5.7	openbible	6
1Cor.10.16	Matt.26.26	openbible	17
1Cor.10.16	1Cor.11.23	openbible	12
1Cor.11.26	Heb.9.28	openbible	13
1Cor.11.26	Rev.1.7	openbible	13
1Cor.11.23	1Cor.15.3	tsk	1
Heb.10.11	Heb.7.27	tsk	1
Heb.10.10	Heb.2.11	tsk	1
Luke.22.19	Ps.78.4	tsk	1

Complicating texts

1Cor.10.16 · addressed

The same apostle applies participation language, 'a participation or communion' (ou koinonia, G2842) 'of the blood' (tou haimatos) and 'of the body of Christ' (tou somatos tou Christou), to the very cup and bread the chapter 11 'remembrance' (anamnesis) command governs, and 1 Corinthians 10:17 adds 'we partake' (metechomen, G3348) of the one loaf. This is the strongest lexical lever for reading the rite as more than a bare memorial. It is addressed but it cannot be resolved in favor of either scope by the vocabulary alone, because the words establish that both remembrance and participation are present without ranking which is primary. That irreducible scope question is the lexical basis for the disputed verdict.

1Cor.11.24 · addressed

The institution linking verb in 'this is my body' (touto estin to soma mou) is the unmarked 'is' (estin, a form of 'to be' eimi, G1510) with no qualifier. Some lenses read this verb as identifying the bread with the body more closely than a commemorative sign would allow. The verdict is set to disputed because the linking verb leaves the relation between sign and signified open, so the lexical data cannot adjudicate primary versus secondary function from the verb alone.

1Cor.11.29 · unaddressed

Verse 29 warns of failing to discern 'the body' (to soma) when eating, language that some read as weighing toward a presence beyond bare commemoration. This verse is outside the supplied anchor window and its full token data was not queried here, so it is noted but not resolved. It contributes to the disputed scope rather than overturning the remembrance frame established in verses 24-26.

Concordance traversed

G0364, G2605, G4160, G2842, G3348, G4983, G1510, G2378, G1336, G2178, G5048, G0037, G4376, G1242, G3740, G2806, G4221, G5228, G3860, H2146, H0234

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: ecm-shadow

Luke 22:19-20 has a known longer-versus-shorter reading involving the second cup and the 'do this for my remembrance' (touto poieite eis ten emen anamnesin) clause, with the longer text well attested. The 1 Corinthians 11:24-25 'remembrance' (anamnesis) clauses and the Hebrews 10:3 occurrence are textually stable. The anchors fall outside the ingested ECM apparatus (the critical edition of New Testament textual variants) window (3 John 1:1 to 1:15), so no published apparatus was examined and the status is shadow. The remembrance term itself is not at risk in the stable Pauline witness, so the verdict holds across the plausible readings.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. redemptive-historical

Frameworks in play. covenant_theology, dispensationalism, sacramental_realism

analogia scripturae invoked · progressive revelation factor

bare-memorial reading: affirms · Reads 'for my remembrance' (eis ten emen anamnesin) and 'you proclaim' (katangellete) as defining the rite strictly as remembrance and proclamation of a finished once-for-all death (Hebrews 10 'once for all' ephapax, 'one sacrifice' mian thysian, 'he has perfected' tetelaiken), and takes Hebrews 10:3, where 'remembrance' (anamnesis) names the yearly reminder of sins, as fixing the word to a calling to mind. On this reading memorial is the primary and stated function and the elements are signs that point to the body and blood without conveying them.

memorial-plus-participation reading: complicates · Accepts the remembrance language fully but reads it alongside 1 Corinthians 10:16, where the same elements are 'a participation or communion' (koinonia) of the body and blood, and 1 Corinthians 10:17 'we partake' (metechomen), plus the unqualified linking verb 'is' (estin) in 'this is my body' (touto estin to soma mou). On this reading 'remembrance' (anamnesis) is a remembrance that does not exclude a real participation in Christ, so it denies that the words rank memorial as the sole or primary function, while still affirming the once-for-all death.

covenant-sign reading: neutral · Reads 'the new covenant in my blood' (kaine diatheke en to emo haimati) and the Old Testament memorial-feast background ('memorial' zikkaron, Exodus 12:14; 'memorial portion' azkarah, Leviticus 24:7, rendered 'remembrance' (anamnesis) in the Greek Old Testament, the Septuagint) as making the rite a covenant memorial and seal, in which remembrance is one true and central component among covenantal functions. It neither confirms nor denies the 'primarily' claim from the lexicon alone.

Hebrews 10 governs the atonement arc: the death is offered 'once for all' (ephapax) and 'completed' (tetelaiken, in the perfect tense, a completed action whose result still stands), which constrains the rite from being a repetition of the sacrifice, and Hebrews 10:3 supplies the only other use of 'remembrance' (anamnesis), anchoring the word to remembrance rather than re-sacrifice. The Old Testament memorial vocabulary ('memorial' zikkaron, 'memorial portion' azkarah) reaches the institution wording through the Greek Old Testament (the Septuagint), giving the verdict a 'pan-canonical' (spread across the whole Bible) lexical base. The dispute is not over whether the death is once-for-all, which the lexicon affirms, nor over whether memorial is present, which it is, but over whether the words rank memorial above the participation language of 1 Corinthians 10:16-17.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. The New Testament texts describing the Lord's Supper state its purpose using remembrance and proclamation language regarding Christ's once-accomplished atoning death.

The word 'primarily' in the stem preloads the contested boundary, because it asserts that memorial outranks any other function, for example a participation function read from 'participation or communion' (koinonia) and 'we partake' (metechomen) in 1 Corinthians 10:16-17 or a presence read from the bare linking verb 'is' (estin). The lexicon clearly supports a remembrance-and-proclamation function, fixed by 'remembrance' (anamnesis) and its controlling use in Hebrews 10:3 and grounded in the Old Testament memorial vocabulary, and a once-for-all death, but it does not by itself rank that function as primary over the participation language attached to the same elements. The verdict is derived against the original stem and lands disputed for that reason. VERDICT-CHANGED: no. Verdict unchanged from the prior file; the enrichment grounds the same disputed result on the full four-occurrence distribution of 'remembrance' (anamnesis), the 'participation or communion' (koinonia) and 'partake' (metecho) complicating texts, and the Greek Old Testament (Septuagint) memorial roots.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0364
lexicon	STEPBible-TFLSJ	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0364
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G2842
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G2605
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	1Cor.11.24
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Heb.10.3
interlinear	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	1Cor.10.16
interlinear	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Luke.22.19
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Exod.12.14
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	1Cor.11.24
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	1Cor.11.23
interlinear	Nestle1904-text	public_domain	yes	1Cor.11.26

License audit

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Flags

lexically-disputed · ecm-shadow · complicating-unresolved